Cowork and OpenWork

General Agents, Chapter 4/12 — Revision & Viva-Prep Cheatsheet (English + Roman Urdu)
Source: agentfactory.panaversity.org/docs/cowork

EN: For people whose day is documents/spreadsheets/email/meetings -- no coding needed. Core idea: this is a co-worker you ASSIGN, not a chatbot you ask. Delegate, don't query.
Roman Urdu: Jin logon ka din documents/spreadsheets/email/meetings mein guzarta hai, unke liye -- coding zaroori nahi. Core idea: yeh co-worker hai jisay aap ASSIGN karte ho, chatbot nahi jo sawal poochta ho. Delegate karo, query nahi.

1. Query vs Assignment + Trust Model

- 'Summarize this PDF' is a query; specifying a multi-step deliverable is an assignment. Worst case in chat = wrong answer; worst case here = confidently executed wrong ACTION.
- **3 trust levers:** Folders (dedicated working folder, not all of Documents), Connectors (read scope != send scope), Approvals (deletions always need explicit permission in both modes).

2. Plan as Leverage + Context Costs Money

- The discipline isn't good prompts -- it's intercepting BETWEEN intent and execution. Each pause point is the cheapest place to course-correct.
- Don't dump whole folders into unprompted context -- have it list first, then read only what's needed.

3. Extending the Tool

- Decision tree: specific procedure -> Skill; external service -> Connector; role bundle -> Plugin; richer surface -> MCP server.
- Subagents spawn for parallel work (e.g. 4 subagents instead of 20 sequential contracts) -- 3 trigger patterns: Fan-out, Dimension, Compare.

4. Safety + the Autonomy Ladder

- **5 rungs:** Watching closely (default) -> Ambient supervision -> Walk away -> Act without asking -> Scheduled. Climb deliberately, drop back when task type changes.
- Prompt injection defense: never run high-autonomy on untrusted content; stop immediately if you see scope creep.

Key Terms Cheatsheet

One line each — English + Roman Urdu.

Term	English	Roman Urdu
Query vs Assignment	A single question vs. a specified multi-step deliverable.	Ek sawal vs ek specified multi-step deliverable.
3 trust levers	Folders, Connectors, Approvals.	Folders, Connectors, Approvals.
Autonomy ladder	Watching closely -> Ambient -> Walk away -> Act without asking -> Scheduled.	Watching closely -> Ambient -> Walk away -> Act without asking -> Scheduled.
Plan as leverage	Intercepting between intent and execution is the cheapest fix point.	Intent aur execution ke beech intercept karna sabse sasta fix point hai.
Read scope != send scope	A connector that can read is not automatically allowed to send/write.	Jo connector parh sakta, automatically bhej/likh nahi sakta.

Quick Self-Check

Question	Answer
What's the key difference between chat's worst case and Cowork's worst case?	Chat's worst case is a contained wrong answer; Cowork's worst case is a confidently EXECUTED wrong action across many files.
Why should you have the agent list a folder before reading it all?	To avoid dumping an entire folder's worth of unprompted, expensive context -- read only what's actually needed.
What always requires explicit permission, even in 'act without asking' mode?	Deletions.
What's the real story behind the HR recruiter's autonomy-ladder mistake?	Promoting screening to 'walk away' caused a credential discrepancy to be missed -- the fix was dropping back to ambient supervision.

Where This Leads / Sources

Leads to: Skills & Connectors, Governance Risk & Responsible Use. Full worked example (Weekly Industry Brief) in 05.

Source: docs/cowork/ (this repo), content originally via Zia Tutor AI connector.